beads; and some household stone implements used for grinding curry or sandalwood.'[16] The gold items were of particular interest because they were in the form of diadems with a hole at each end for tying them round the forehead, suggesting that these were symbols of kingship. Among the bronze objects were lids with finely executed finials in animal shapes depicting elephants, tigers, buffalo, goats and chickens.

Continuing excavations at Adichallanur by the ASI have uncovered many more burials as well as evidence of extensive opencast mining for copper, iron and gold, although no identifiable township has yet been located.[17] A few early Tamil-Brahmi letters have also been found scratched on potsherds, possibly dating as early as the second century BCE, as well as a six-character inscription scratched inside an urn which the discoverer has rather optimistically dated to the fifth century BCE.

But that is not to dismiss the Sangam tradition as nothing more than a Tamil nationalist fantasy.

It has been noted that the years of the three supposed Sangams all involve multiples of thirty-seven, suggesting a Jain involvement, since the Jains considered *Sankhyana*, the science of numbers, to be one of the highest accomplishments of their monks. That very word 'Sangam' is itself derived from the Sanskrit word *Sangha*, first used by Jains to describe their assembly of monks and nuns – and afterwards adopted by the Buddhists. The bulk of the early Tamil literature that has survived is credited to Jain authors, including three of five surviving Tamil epics – *Cilappatikaram*, *Civaka Cintamani* and *Valayapathi* – as well as a sixth epic that did not survive. Other writings such as the *Kural* and *Nalatiyar*, as well as a number of important grammars and lexicons, are also credited to Jain authors. Some scholars have even suggested that the oldest surviving Tamil text, Tholkappiyar*'s Tolkappiyam*, may have